population – non-Muslims who under Islamic law should have been protected persons. In April 1669 a general order was issued for the destruction of Hindu and Jain temples and their replacement by mosques, along with a ban on public worship and the restriction of Hindu festivals. In practice, these orders were rarely implemented and were less damaging than Aurangzeb's reimposition in 1679 of *jizya*, the infidel tax that had been abolished by his great-grandfather Emperor Akbar more than a century earlier. This was followed by a Hindu pilgrim tax and further bans on Hindus travelling in palanquins, on elephants or on horseback. Hindus who converted to Islam were given four rupees per male and two rupees per female. So it went on, year by year, despite the arguments of his ministers, although it is true to say that Aurangzeb's impact was far great in the north than it was south of the Narmada.

Aurangzeb had hoped to turn Aurangabad into the centre of Islamic culture in Asia, the Indian equivalent of the Damascus of the Umayyads or the Cordoba of the tenth-century Caliphate of Al-Hakam. In the event, the octogenarian emperor's last years were spent in the saddle as he rode from one battlefield to another, his state all but bankrupt, the once mighty edifice of the Mughal dominion falling about his ears. After his death in March 1707 his empire imploded. Marathas, Sikhs, Persians and Afghans, to say nothing of the British and the French, moved in to fill the power vacuum. Aurangzeb's conquests of Golconda and Bijapur had brought the last of the five Deccan Sultanates under Mughal rule but as his empire splintered his local viceroys seized the opportunity to make themselves masters in their own lands, with the Nizam of Hyderabad to the fore. As Aurangzeb's descendants continued to squabble among themselves the last of their authority drained away, culminating in the blinding of Aurangzeb's great-great-grandson Shah Alam II by a mad Afghan warlord in 1788.